Muslims essentially took away Indians' moral right to condemn violence against Hindus in East Pakistan. That was not a Hindu nationalist position but a classically Gandhian approach as an *Indian* nationalist.

History has often been contested terrain in India, but its revival in the context of twenty-first century politics is a sobering sign that the past continues to have a hold over the Hindutva movement in the present. While the Mughals will be demonised as a way of delegitimising Indian Muslims (who are stigmatised as 'Babur ke aulad', the sons of Babur rather than of the Indian soil), the arguments over Patel confirm that he and other heroes of the freedom struggle will be hijacked to the present ruling party's attempts to appropriate a halo of nationalism that none of its forebears has done anything to earn.

HINDUTVA AND CULTURE

If the rewriting of the historical past is a vital first objective of the Hindutva project, the second is the removal of what they see as the various accretions to the Hindu idea that had arisen over the years. These accretions, to the more rabid of the Hindutva brigades, include the acceptance of difference that Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan had celebrated. Indeed, the distinctive difference between what one might call the Nehruvian version of Indian nationalism and the Hindutva version of it is the latter's active rejection of different interpretations and the diversity of representations for which the Indian cultural tradition had become known, and which other Hindus portrayed as the strength of their culture.

One aspect of this is the relentless campaign being waged against heterodox interpretations of Hinduism itself—and this in the name of a faith which proudly includes no concept of heresy. Thus Hindutva mobs attacked and vandalised the invaluable Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute's library in Pune to protest its co-operation with the research work of the historian James Laine, whose book allegedly cast aspersions on the parentage of Shivaji. The courts offer a less dramatic form of censorship, since Hindutva activists can invoke Section 295(a) of the Indian Penal Code, which criminalises insults to religious sentiments, though the intent was only to outlaw inflammatory writings published